

2026 AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS CHAMPIONSHIP PROBLEM SOLVING ALPHA CANBERRA

NAME: _____

DATE OF BIRTH: _____

Please circle your age group:

- U8 (born in 2019 or after) U14 (born in 2013 or after)
- U10 (born in 2017 or after) U16 (born in 2011 or after)
- U12 (born in 2015 or after) U18 (born in 2009 or after)

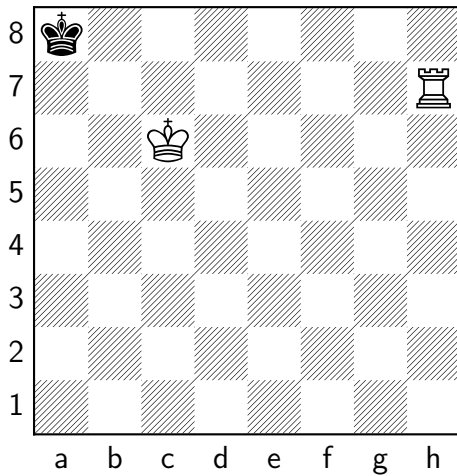
Please circle: Boy or Girl

Please read the following rules.

- You have up to 2 hours for the problem solving paper. You may not need all that time. You may leave after handing in your answers.
- The questions generally go from easy to hard, so it's best to start from the beginning and go in order.
- You can use your chess board and pieces to help you.
- Each page show a question and a point you can obtain. Please write your answers in the space under each picture. Altogether, the test has 100 points. Even if you don't give perfect answers, you can still get some partial points.
- For endgame puzzles, show enough moves to reach a position where you are clearly winning or drawing.
- You don't have to finish them all, do your best and solve as many puzzles as you can.

Enjoy the problem solving.

Example Q1. Mate in 2.

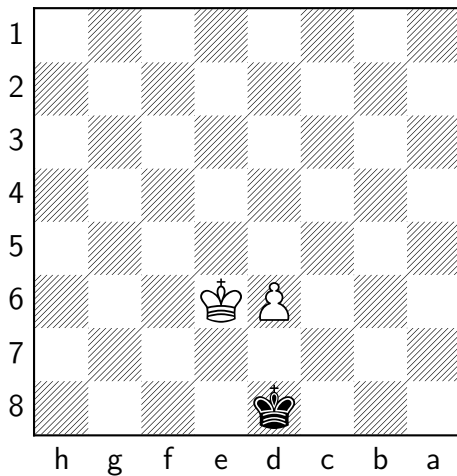


☐ The open box shows White's move.

Answer:

1. Kb6 Kb8 ← Write the first White move, then the first Black move.
2. Rh8# (1-0) ← Write the second White move, which is a mate.

Example Q2. Black moves and draws.

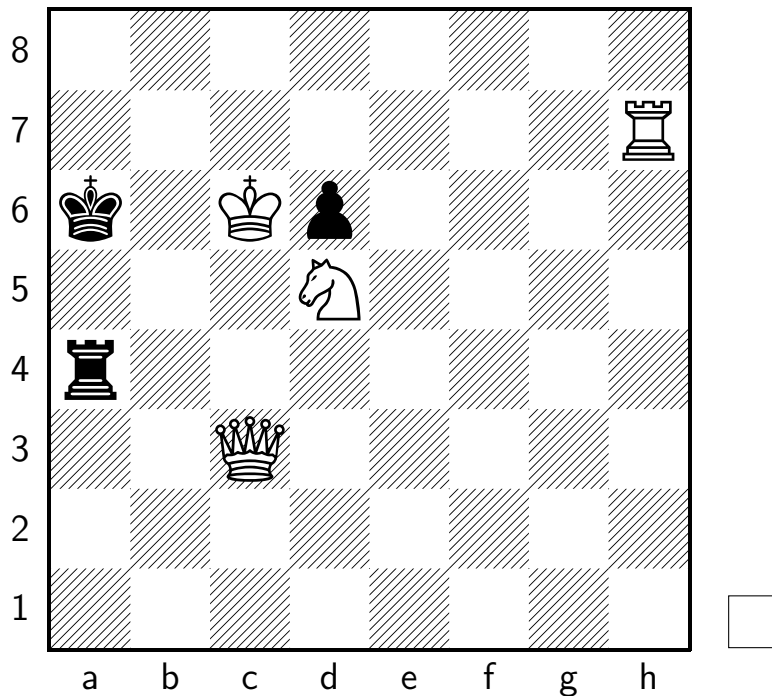


☒ The closed box shows Black's move.

Answer:

1. ... Ke8
2. d7+ Kd8
3. Kd6 (draw) ← Write enough moves showing a clear draw position.

Q1. Mate in 2. (4 marks)

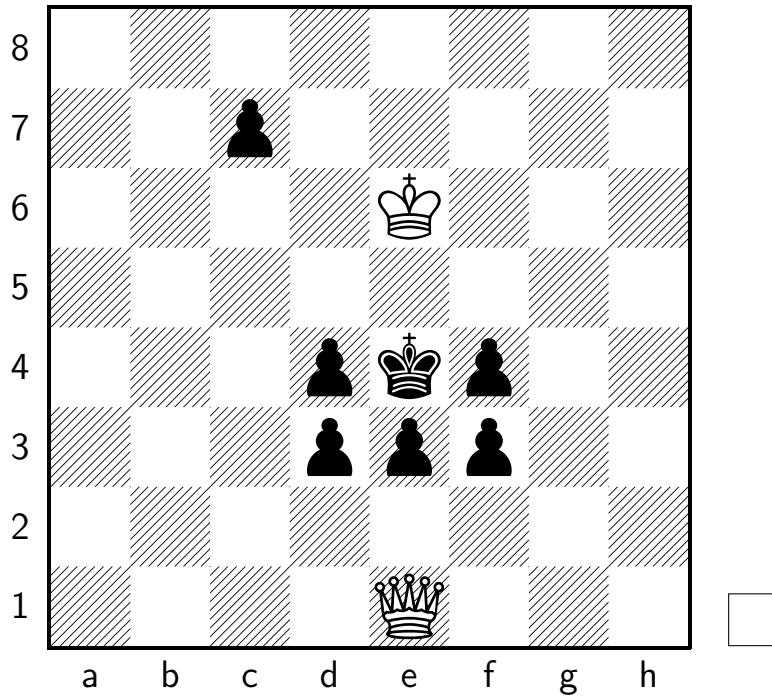


Answer:

1 ♔d3+ ♖c4 2 ♕xc4+ ♔a4 3 ♕b4# takes 3 moves. The right answer starts from Queen sacrifice, **1 ♕a5+ ♖xa5 2 ♘b4#**. If Black King takes White Queen, **1... ♔xa5 2 ♖a7#**.

It is very important that you can only get the point when you answer the checkmate moves with a given moves (in this question, 2 moves, not 3 moves.)

Q2. Mate in 2 (4 marks)



Answer:

1 ♔a5! covers all Black's moves.

1... d2 2 ♕f5#

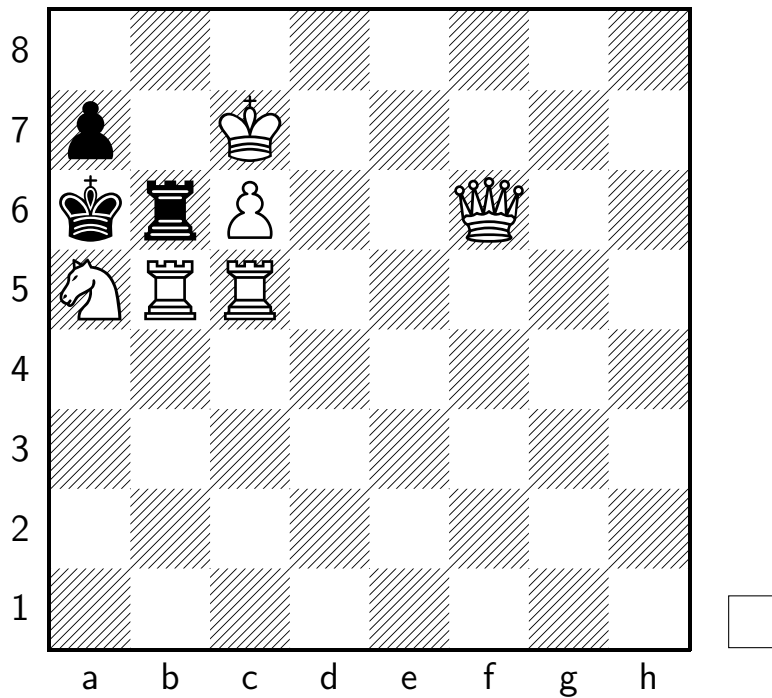
1... e2 2 ♕e5#

1... f2 2 ♕d5#

1... c5 2 ♕a8#

Source: Thomas Salthouse, Falkirk Herald, 1914 (YACDB: 22264)

Q3. Mate in 2. (4 marks)



Answer:

1 ♔f1

1 ♚... ♖xb5 2 ♔xb5#

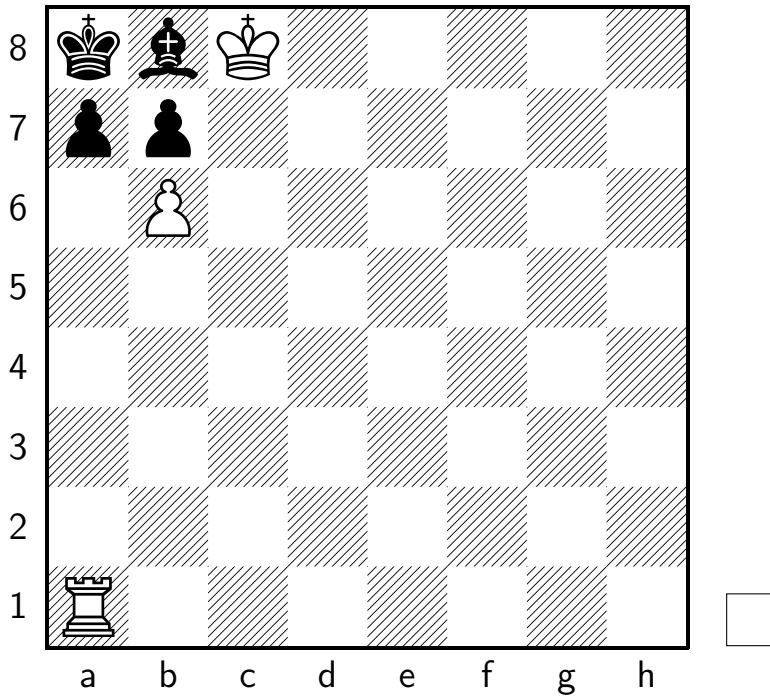
1 ♚... ♖xc6+ 2 ♖xc6#

1 ♚... ♖b7+ 2 ♖xb7#

1 ♔a1 fails as 1 ♚... ♖xb5 2 ♘b3+ ♖a5 3 ♖xa5#/Qxa5#

Source: Cornelis Goldschmeding, problem (Zagreb), 1957 (YACDB: 8721)

Q4. Mate in 2. (4 marks)

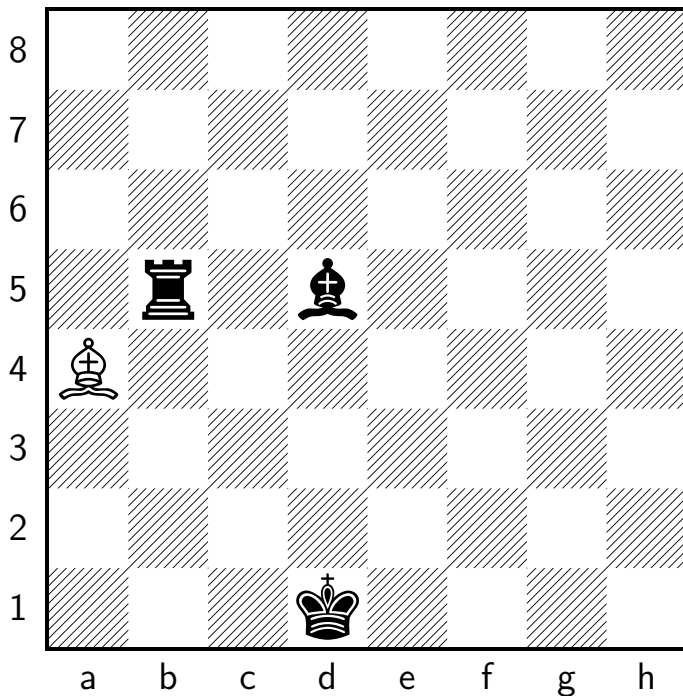


Answer:

This is one of the most famous and hard to solve "Mate in 2" puzzles. The surprising first move is **1 ♖a6!**. If the b7 Pawn takes the Rook, **1... bxa6 2 ♜b7#**. If the bishop moves, **1... ♗h2 2 ♖xa7#**. The Bishop moves to any legal squares (c7, d6, e5, f4, g3) are also correct answers.

Source: Paul Morphy, 1910 (YACDB: 625426)

Q5. What is the missing piece? Which turns? What is the position of the missing piece? Then, answer the last few moves.



Answer:

Article 1.2 of "Laws of Chess" says "Leaving one's own king under attack, exposing one's own king to attack and also 'capturing' the opponent's king are not allowed."

1. King can not be captured, so the one missing piece is White king.
2. Black king is in check by White Bishop. You can not leave your king under attack. Therefore, Black's move now.
3. What is the previous White's move? It is not White's Bishop move, so White King moved from b3 to c3, which creates discovery check to Black King.
- 4.

-1. Kb3-Kxc3+

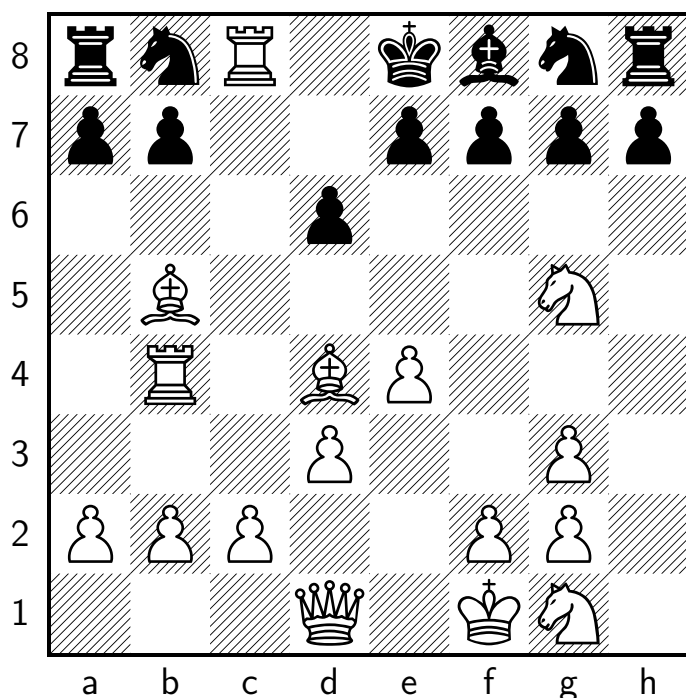
-2. c2-c4 -Bd5+

1... ♖d5+ 2 c4 bxc3+ 3 ♗xc3+

This puzzle was used in 2019 Q10.

Source: Raymond M. Smullyan: The Chess Mysteries of the Arabian Knights

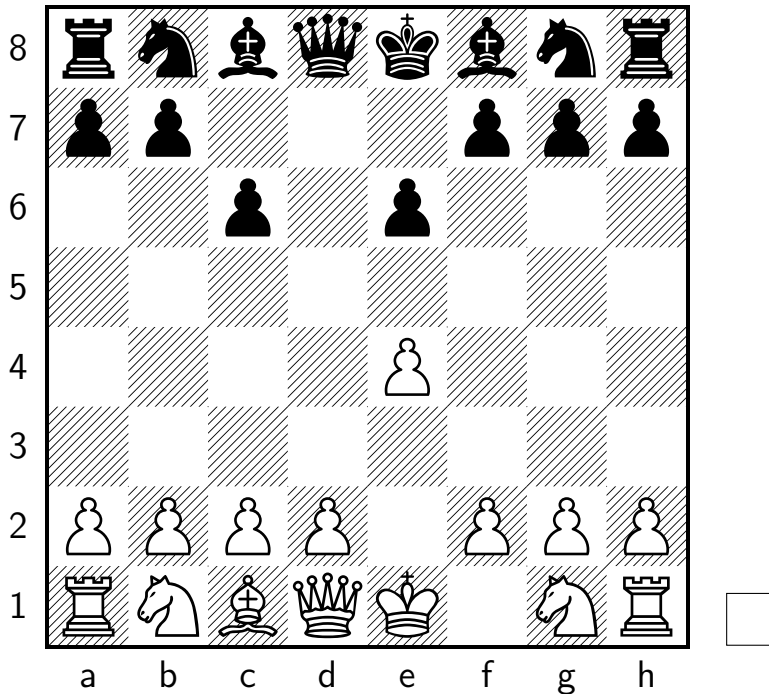
Q6. WHO moved last? WHICH piece was moved from WHERE to WHERE?



Answer:

Black king is now in check, actually under double check from Rc8 and Bb5. It is illegal to move into check or leave your king in check. Therefore, the last move is made by White. Double check always comes from discovery check and check by that move. The only possible move is a move of Rook from c6 to c8.

Q7. The position below occurred after the Black's 4th move from the starting position. Answer the moves to reach this position.



Answer:

This type of chess problem is called "Proof game", a type of retrograde analysis. This position is easily reached by 1 e4 e6 2 ♖b5 c6 3 ♙xc6 dxc6. However, this problem is asking the same position after Black's 4th move. There should be illogical, but legal White and Black move. The answer is

1 e4 e6.

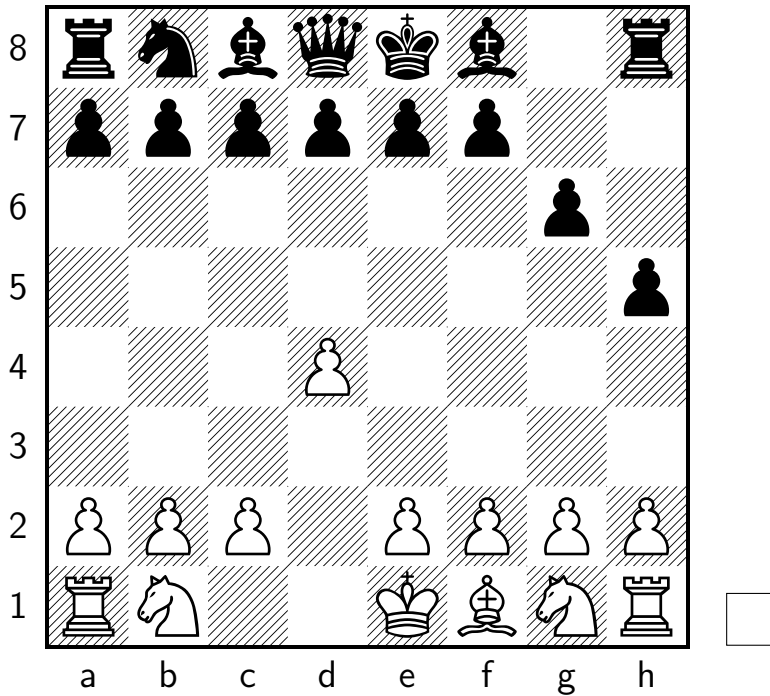
2 ♙b5+ ♔e7.

3 ♙xd7 c6.

4 ♙e8 ♔xe8.

Source: Tibor Orbán, Die Schwalbe, 1976

Q8. The position below occurred after the Black's 4th move from the starting position. Answer the moves to reach this position.



Answer:

1 d4 ♘h6.

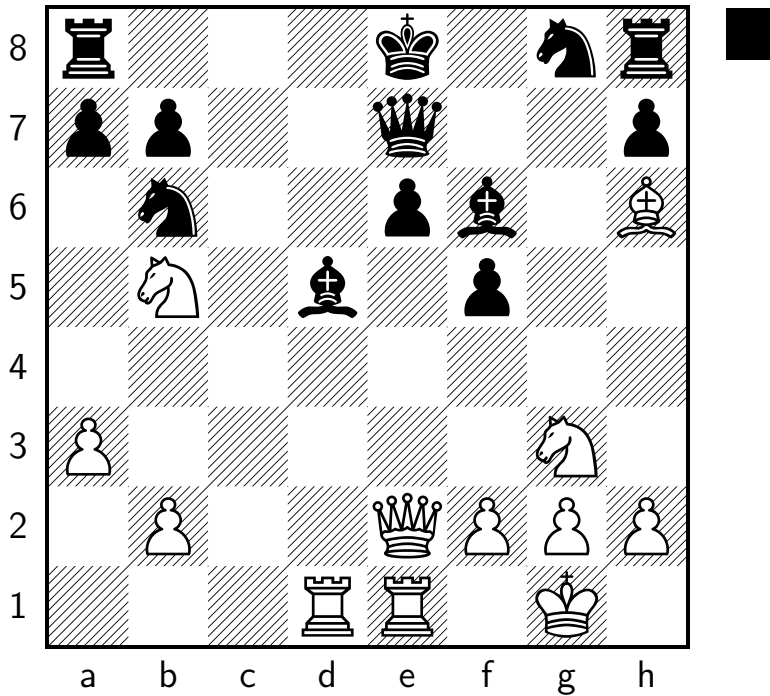
2 ♙xh6 g×h6.

3 ♔d3 h5.

4 ♚g6 h×g6.

Source:

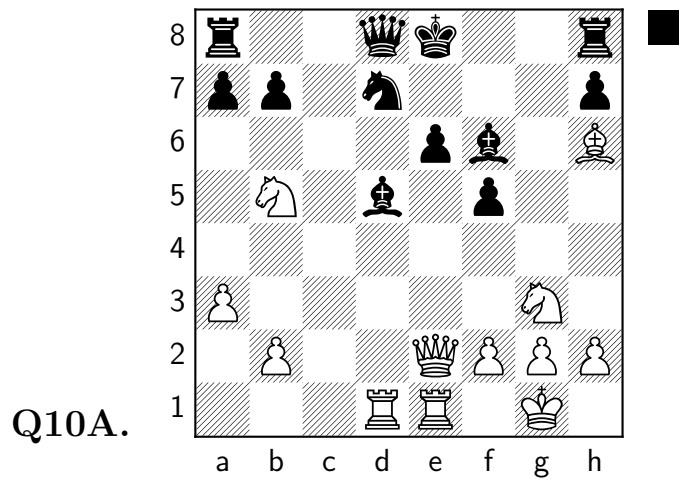
Q9. Helpmate in 1. What is Black's move to make "Mate in 1"?
 Answer Black's move, then White's mate move.



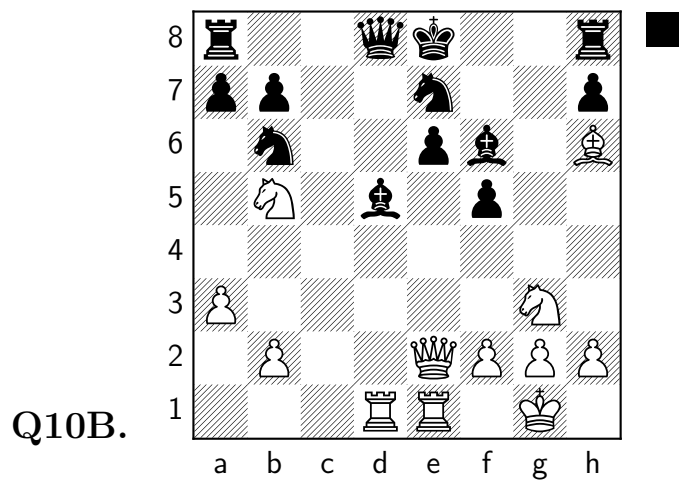
Answer:

1... ♔f7?? 2 ♕h5#

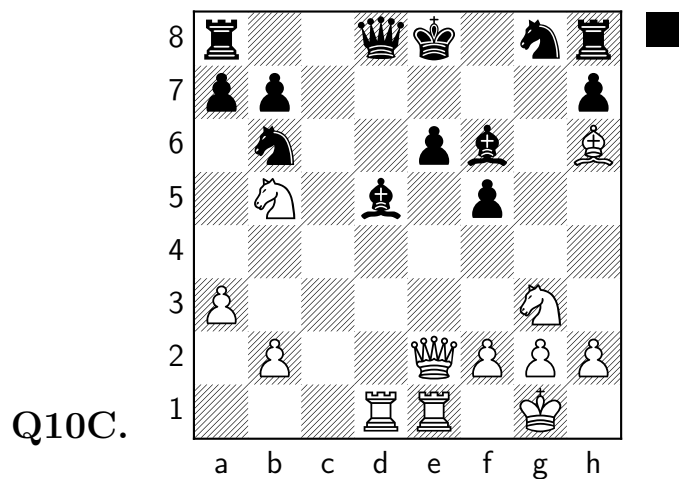
10. Helpmate in 1. White's positions are all same as the previous question.



Answer: 1... ♖e7?? 2 ♔h5#



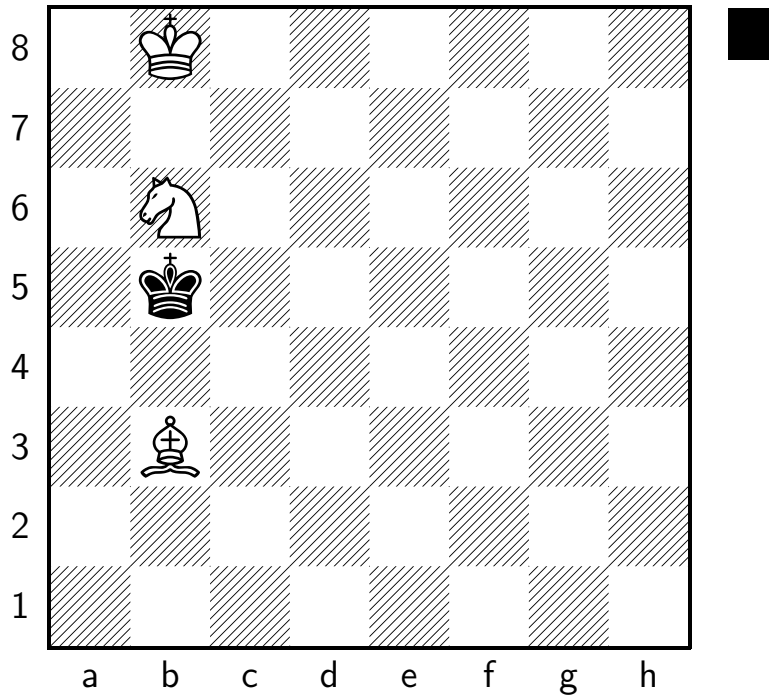
Answer: 1... ♘d7?? 2 ♘d6#



Answer: 1... ♔d7?? 2 ♚xe6#

Source: Jeff Coakley, Winning Chess Puzzles for Kids Vol. 2

Q11. Helpmate in 3.



Answer:

0... ♔a6?

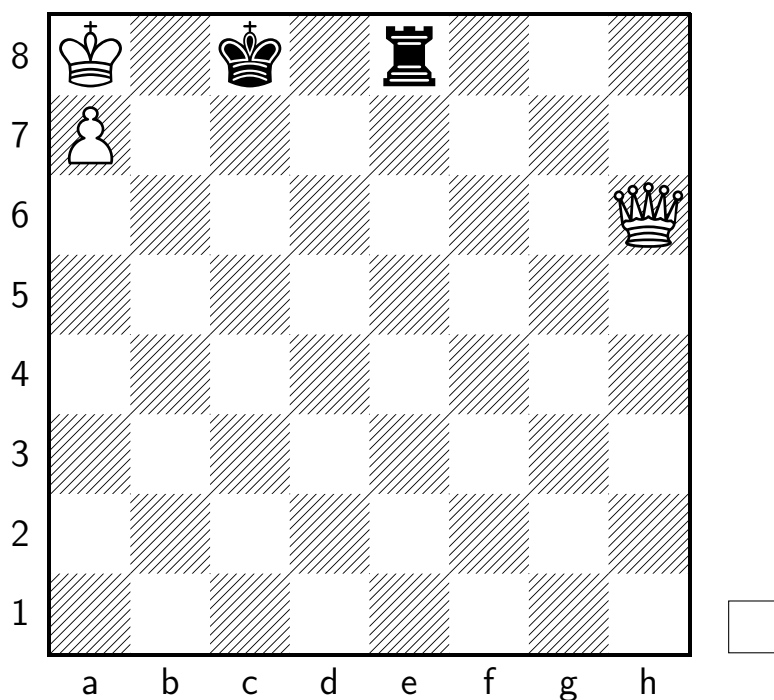
1 ♔c7 ♔a7?

2 ♞c8+ ♔a8??

3 ♞d5#

With Black's help, Knight and Bishop endgame is quite easy.

Q12. Selfmate in 2. White forces Black to mate White King himself in Black's 2nd move.



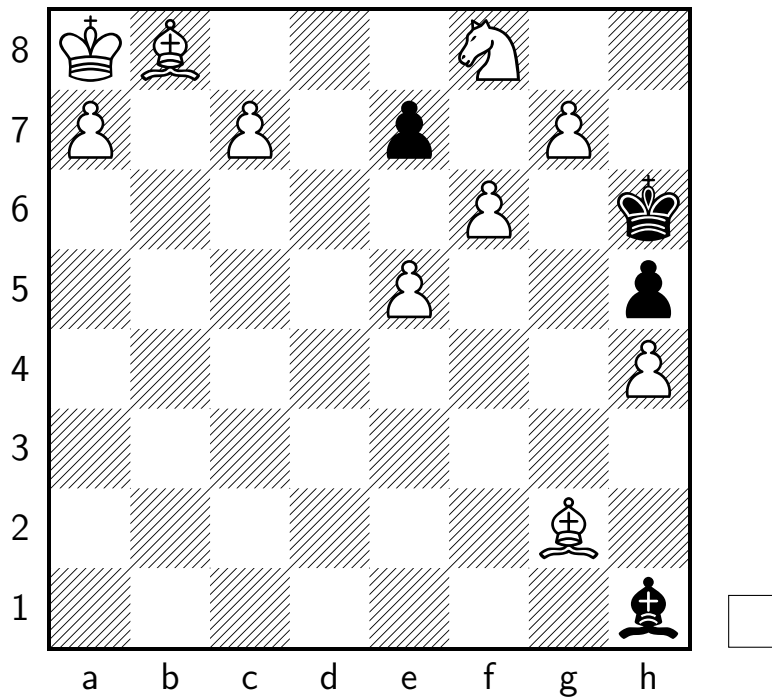
Answer:

1 ♔c6+ ♚d8

2 ♔c7+ ♚xc7#

Source: Wilhelm Krämer, Die Schwalbe, 1928 (YACDB: 106430)

Q13. Selfmate in 2. White forces Black to mate White King himself in a given moves.



Answer:

1 c8♞ e×f6

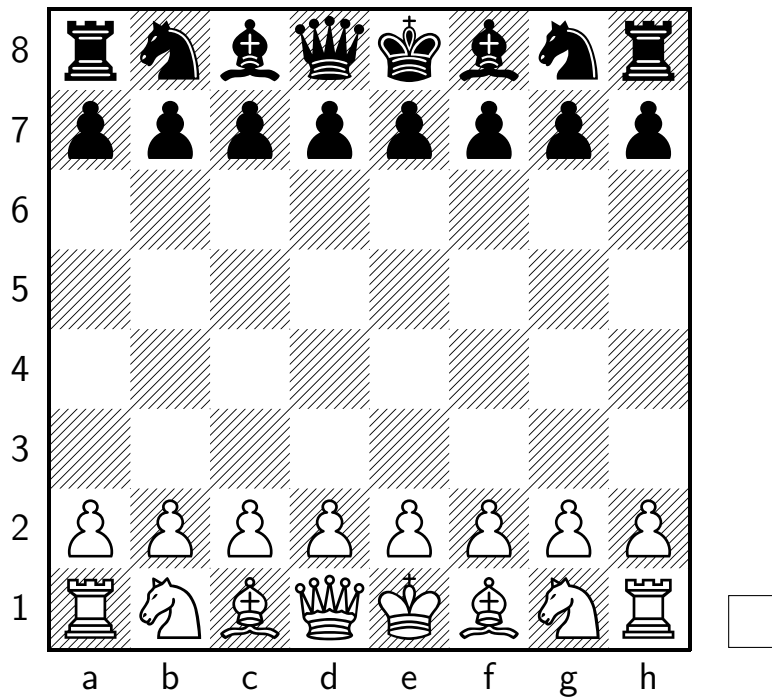
2 e×f6 ♜×g2♯

If 1... e6, another waiting move is 2 g8♜, then 2... ♜×g2♯.

Do you understand why two underpromotions are necessary?

Source: Wolfgang Pauly, The Theory of Pawn Promotion, 1912 (YACDB: 47304)

Q14. White to play. Who wins?



Answer:

This is the world's hardest chess problem. We hope you will be one step closer to the answer in 2026 Australian Junior Championships.

Happy Problem Solving!

Source: Composer unknown, date unknown